September 25, 2026

Policymakers and Industry Stakeholders Discuss ROAD Implementation and a Potential 2.0 Package.

On Wednesday (September 23), Politico held an event titled “Policy Outlook: Housing Affordability.” During this event, policymakers and industry stakeholders came together to discuss housing affordability, next steps in implementing the recently enacted 21st Century ROAD to Housing Act, and the potential for a future “ROAD 2.0” package and what that may include.

Highlights.

- **Fireside Chat with Sen. Lisa Blunt Rochester (D-DE)**. Sen. Rochester (D-DE) highlighted bipartisan support for housing reform and called for sufficient funding to implement the 21st Century ROAD to Housing Act. She said any ROAD 2.0 package should give greater attention to what families can afford, including rental assistance, while supporting simpler permitting to increase housing supply. Blunt Rochester also highlighted her work with Sen. Moreno on pattern books, which could pre-approve home designs to simplify permitting. Blunt Rochester also noted the role AI could play in home design and searching but warned about the risk of bias in algorithms.

- **Amazon’s Housing Fund Program.** Amazon’s Brian Kenner outlined the company’s $3.6 billion housing fund, highlighting its 99-year affordability commitments and partnerships tailored to local needs. He cited the conversion of Alexandria’s vacant Victory Center office building into housing as an example of private investment helping make affordable housing projects possible.

- **Former FHA, HUD, and Housing Policy Panel.** Former FHA Commissioner Frank Cassidy, Former HUD Acting Secretary, and other panelists discussed ROAD’s implementation and priorities for future legislation. Bipartisan Policy Center’s Dennis Shea and other panelists emphasized the importance of ensuring funding for authorized grant programs. Cassidy urged faster construction approvals and incentives for private lenders to offer small dollar mortgages. Todman stressed that agency rules should follow congressional intent, protect rental supply, and avoid unintended consequences for consumers. Panelists also discussed expanding housing options and encouraging further investment through ROAD 2.0.

See below for more details from our select coverage of the event. As always, please reach out with any questions

Fireside Chat with Sen. Lisa Blunt Rochester (D-DE).

Speakers:

- Sen. Lisa Blunt Rochester (D-DE), Member, Senate Banking, Housing and Urban Affairs Committee
- Victoria Guida, Politico (*Moderator)*

Housing and Bipartisanship

Sen. Blunt Rochester said she has heard from all types of people, old and young, who cannot afford housing even with a full-time job. She emphasized that, because this is such a wide-ranging problem, everyone should be working towards solutions. She also explained that the challenges to pass the 21st Century ROAD to Housing Act stemmed more from disagreements between chambers than between parties.

"ROAD 2.0"

Guida asked Sen. Blunt Rochester whether there was any hope for a potential "ROAD 2.0" package. Blunt Rochester said members of Congress are already looking toward developing a second package; however, she noted that the initial ROAD package has yet to be fully implemented and still requires significant appropriations. Blunt Rochester pointed out that while the original ROAD package focused on supply-side solutions, she supported a second ROAD package to include more demand-side solutions. Specifically, Blunt Rochester identified the Choice Neighborhoods program and rental assistance as two demand topics that she wants to work on.

AI and Housing

Guida asked Blunt Rochester to discuss AI policy and how AI is used for underwriting and rental applications. Rochester explained that AI can be helpful, explaining that it has been used to design homes and aid in finding homes using Zillow. Although, she identified algorithmic bias as a concern, noting that Congress will play a role in implementing safeguards.

Pattern Books

Blunt Rochester voiced support for the federal government to incentivize local and state governments to simplify processes and make zoning and obtaining permits easier, specifically through the use of pattern books, noting her work with Sen. Moreno (R-OH).

Healthcare

Guida asked Blunt Rochester to explain what Democrats are doing to bring down the cost of living. Blunt Rochester said that she has heard from constituents that they want Congress to address corruption and the high costs of healthcare, pointing to Affordable Care Act cuts included in the One Big Beautiful Bill Act as a concern for many.

Fireside Chat with Amazon's Brian Kenner: Private Sectors Role in Housing Affordability.

Speakers:

- Brian Kenner, Global Director of Community Engagement, Amazon
- Cally Baute, Chief Commercial Officer for POLITICO

Amazon Housing Fund

Baute asked Kenner to describe how Amazon is helping to address housing affordability issues. Kenner discussed the Amazon Housing Fund (AHF), noting that targets around 35,000 units and focuses on families of 4 making around $100,000 a year. Baute then asked how the AHF can make

an impact. Kenner explained that Amazon has the ability to work quickly on housing projects and noted that the AHF has much more flexibility than traditional routes. Baute asked Kenner how the fund keeps housing affordable long term. Kenner explained that their projects have a 99-year covenant, compared with the market standard of 30 years. Baute then asked which partnerships are best right now to promote and support the housing market. Kenner emphasized that non-financial institutions are essential to getting affordable housing off the ground and making it work.

Panel Discussion with FHFA, HUD, and Other Stakeholders: ROAD and What Comes Next.

Speakers:

- Frank Cassidy, Senior Managing Director, Walker and Dunlop; Former FHA Commissioner
- Adrianne Todman, CEO, National Rental Home Council; Former Acting HUD Secretary
- Colleen Green, Director, DC Department of Housing and Community Development
- Dennis Shea, Bipartisan Policy Center
- Cassandra Dumay, Housing Policy Reporter at POLITICO (*Moderator*)

Access to Small-Dollar Mortgages

Dumay asked Cassidy to explain what would make the FHA's small-dollar loan pilot work better. Cassidy said private lenders need a reason to offer mortgages under $100,000 and explained that FHA relies on these lenders. Cassidy suggested making the loan process simpler to get them involved.

Housing Supply and Public-Private Cooperation

Dumay asked Cassidy to discuss the role of subsidies in the housing market. Cassidy argued that we cannot subsidize our way out of the housing crisis, explaining that incentivizing the private sector to build more homes is the main way to address it. Dumay then asked Todman for her thoughts on Cassidy's assessment. Todman said private builders and public agencies must work together, and that government should help decide where and how to build homes. Cassidy added that federal officials should push local governments to cut red tape and help developers build more homes.

Rental Housing and Consumer Protections

Regarding agency regulations, Todman informed Dumay that new rules should align with congressional intent and protect both renters and home sellers. She cautioned that policy changes may inadvertently disadvantage renters by failing to meet rental demand, emphasizing that policies should benefit consumers while minimizing unintended consequences. Todman further noted that although most rental properties are owned by small landlords, large investors play a significant role in developing and maintaining housing availability.

Local Housing and Infrastructure Priorities

When Dumay asked what local housing success would look like for D.C., Green pointed Community Development Block Grant (CDBG) funding as an important step and that raising FHA loan limits would help, since housing in D.C. costs more than the national average.

ROAD Implementation and Priorities for Future Housing Legislation

When asked about the implementation of the ROAD to Housing Act, Shea noted that the law allows for grant programs but does not provide funding. He urged Congress to allocate HUD the funds it needs to start these programs. Green added that competitive grants make local planning uncertain and called for steady funding.

Dumay asked if the same negotiation style used for ROAD could work for future housing laws. Shea noted that most disagreements were between the House and Senate, but that housing has wide bipartisan support. Todman said ROAD aimed to cut regulations and urged officials to act quickly but carefully. Cassidy advocated for expedited approvals and increased housing supply, emphasizing that delays hurt developers because they cannot generate revenue while awaiting zoning and permit approvals. Todman called for more rental housing near good schools so families could live in those school districts without having to purchase. Green called for incentives to bring in investment and give people more choices about where to live. Shea supported keeping the bipartisan focus on supply and helping families find homes in popular areas.